BANGLADESH

NEW OUTFIT DIVIDES DHAKA

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AFP

Seven months after tumultuous events changed the course of the country, a new wind is picking up in Bangladesh's polity—and getting caught, right upon its birth, in its twisted arcs. On February 28, a grand political event at Manik Mia Avenue in Dhaka marked the launch of the National Citizen Party (NCP), an outfit born out of the July 2024 student-led uprising that overthrew ex-prime minister Sheikh Hasina. Given that backdrop, its inherent formative contradictions didn't take long showing up.

An evolution of the Jatiyo Nagorik Committee—the political platform formed after the August uprising—the NCP positions itself as a centrist force aiming to rebuild Bangladesh through democracy, social justice and economic reform. Nahid Islam, a former cabinet member in the interim government of Muhammad Yunus, took the stage as its convenor, outlining the party's vision for a "second republic" that would eliminate autocratic rule and draft a new democratic constitution. Yet, within hours of its inception, the party found itself entangled in ideological battles and accusations of Islamist infiltration.

The first major controversy erupted within hours of the NCP's launch. The inclusion of Mohammad Muntasir Rahman, an openly gay activist and key figure in the July uprising, in the 151-member national committee sparked outrage among conservative factions. Two prominent student leaders, Md Sarjis Alam and Hasnat Abdullah, stated on social media: "We are Muslims first, and anything that goes against Islamic values will have no space in our politics."

Muntasir's subsequent removal from the committee disappointed liberal supporters and raised concerns about the NCP's ability to stand up to Islamic hardliners. Many saw this as a compromise of the party's core principle "to build a pluralistic and prosperous society by preserving the nation's ethnic, social, gender, religious, and cultural values and diversity". They ask if the NCP could truly represent all Bangladeshis, including marginalised communities.

Before the party's launch, reports emerged that members of the Bangladesh Jamaat-e-Islami and its student wing, Chhatra Shibir, were sidelined in the Jatiyo Nagorik Committee.

PARTY WATCH

- **Student activists from last year's uprising have launched the National Citizen Party on February 28 with a national committee of 151 members**
- **It will soon launch a country-wide march; take part in polls expected within a year**
- **However, many question their ideology, suspecting it to be accommodative of Islamist ideals**
- **Others say the interim government is backing the NCP to undercut BNP and others, usher change in a controlled way**